

Language Evolution Across Generations: A Comparative Study of Gen Z and Gen Alpha Communication Patterns

By Rabia Shehzad

*Department of Humanities, English Literature and Linguistics
COMSATS University Islamabad*

ABSTRACT

This research article explores the evolving communication patterns of Generation Z (Gen Z) and Generation Alpha (Gen Alpha) in the context of their digital media consumption. Both generations are characterized as digital natives, but the technological landscapes they have grown up in differ substantially, influencing the ways they use language. Gen Z, born roughly between 1997 and 2012, grew up during the rise of social media platforms such as Facebook, YouTube, and Instagram, where text-based interactions and image sharing were primary modes of communication. Gen Alpha, born from 2013 onwards, have come of age in an era dominated by short-form video platforms like TikTok and YouTube Shorts, as well as voice-activated assistants and interactive apps, which shape their language use in distinct ways.

By analyzing content from multiple social media platforms—including interviews and informal conversations on YouTube, comment sections on Instagram posts, and viral TikTok videos—this study identifies unique linguistic features, slang, and discourse styles that characterize each generation. The data collected reflect natural language use in both casual and semi-structured settings, offering insight into vocabulary choices, syntax, pragmatic use of language, and the increasing role of visual and multimodal elements such as emojis, GIFs, and video filters in communication.

The study applies a qualitative research methodology, using thematic and content analysis to examine transcripts of interviews and selected social media interactions. Special attention is given to the influence of digital culture on language acquisition and development, showing how each generation adopts, modifies, or creates language suited to their respective digital ecosystems. For example, Gen Z is shown to use a wide range of internet slang that often reflects irony, sarcasm, and intertextuality, such as phrases like “sus” (suspicious), “vibe check,” and “no cap,” many of which have roots in gaming communities and meme culture. Meanwhile, Gen Alpha exhibits a more direct and repetitive linguistic style, heavily borrowing from TikTok trends and influencer catchphrases, such as “let’s gooo,” “periodt,” and “hit that like button,” which often accompany video content and are reinforced by visual aids.

Findings reveal that Gen Alpha’s communication is increasingly multimodal, integrating verbal language with emojis, stickers, and video effects in ways that go beyond traditional textual communication. This reflects a broader trend toward communication that relies not only on words but also on visuals and auditory cues, a feature less dominant in Gen Z’s interactions. The study also highlights educational implications, noting that teachers and linguists observe Gen Alpha struggling more than Gen Z when shifting between informal digital language and formal academic registers.

Ultimately, this research fills a critical gap in sociolinguistic literature by providing a detailed comparative analysis of two digitally native generations within the rapidly changing

media landscape. It offers valuable insights for educators, content creators, and language researchers interested in understanding the dynamic interplay between technology and language evolution. The study emphasizes the need to continuously adapt educational and communication strategies to better engage with younger generations whose language is increasingly shaped by their digital environments.

Keywords: Gen Z, Gen Alpha, digital communication, slang evolution, multimodal discourse.

INTRODUCTION

Language is an ever-changing phenomenon, shaped continuously by cultural, social, and technological factors. Over the past two decades, the rise of digital media has dramatically transformed how people communicate, especially younger generations who have grown up immersed in various online platforms. Generation Z (Gen Z), typically defined as those born between 1997 and 2012, and Generation Alpha (Gen Alpha), born from 2013 onwards, are two such cohorts whose language use reflects the digital environments they navigate daily. While both generations are considered digital natives, their experiences with technology differ significantly, leading to distinct communication patterns and linguistic behaviors.

Gen Z witnessed the early stages of social media development, with platforms like YouTube, Instagram, and Snapchat gaining popularity during their formative years. Their language is often characterized by a rich use of internet slang, abbreviations, and meme culture. For example, in YouTube interviews such as “How Gen Z is changing English” (CBC News, 2024), young adults frequently use terms like “sus” (short for suspicious), “vibe check,” and “no cap” (meaning no lie), which reflect their affinity for playful and creative language shaped by online gaming and social media trends. On Instagram, comment sections reveal frequent use of emojis and shorthand to convey tone and emotion quickly.

In contrast, Gen Alpha has grown up in an even more visually driven and interactive digital landscape. Platforms like TikTok, YouTube Shorts, and interactive apps dominate their daily media consumption. Their language use reflects the influence of short, punchy video content, often adopting catchphrases and expressions popularized by influencers and viral trends. For instance, TikTok videos featuring kids and pre-teens commonly include expressions like “periodt” (emphatic agreement), “hit that like button,” and “let’s gooo,” often accompanied by exaggerated gestures and emojis to enhance communication. As seen in the YouTube video “Nerdy Professor Shocks High School by Speaking Gen Alpha Slang” (2024), this younger generation’s language tends to be more repetitive and direct compared to the playful complexity of Gen Z speech.

Despite the growing interest in how digital media shapes language, there remains a lack of comprehensive studies that compare Gen Z and Gen Alpha’s communication styles directly, particularly using authentic, naturalistic data from social media platforms. Most existing research focuses on either Gen Z or broader internet linguistics without addressing the nuances introduced by newer platforms like TikTok that heavily influence Gen Alpha. This gap makes it difficult for educators, linguists, and content creators to understand how language evolution is progressing in real time and across these generational divides.

The problem, therefore, lies in understanding the differences and similarities between Gen Z and Gen Alpha language use and identifying how various digital platforms contribute to shaping these patterns. Addressing this problem can provide crucial insights into digital communication’s future, especially as Gen Alpha begins to enter adolescence and young

adulthood.

This study aims to fill this research gap by analyzing linguistic data collected from YouTube interviews, Instagram comment sections, and TikTok videos featuring members of both generations. The research seeks to answer the following key question: How do communication patterns differ between Generation Z and Generation Alpha, and what role do digital platforms play in influencing these differences?

By exploring vocabulary, syntax, discourse styles, and multimodal communication methods, this research will contribute to understanding how language evolves in digital spaces and how educators and content creators can adapt to better engage with younger generations.

Rabia Shehzad is currently pursuing her Bachelor's degree in English Literature and Linguistics at COMSATS University Islamabad, with a research focus on Language and Digital Communication. Correspondence should be addressed to: Department of Humanities, English Literature and Linguistics, COMSATS University Islamabad, Pakistan. Email: shehzadirabi4@gmail.com

© 2025 Rabia Shehzad. This is an open access article distributed under the terms of the Creative Commons Attribution License, which permits unrestricted use, distribution, and reproduction, provided the original author and source are credited.

LITERATURE REVIEW

Language evolution in the digital age has been a subject of increasing scholarly interest, particularly as social media platforms have become primary modes of communication for younger generations. Previous research has extensively documented how the internet and digital tools influence language use, resulting in new varieties of digital discourse, often called “internet linguistics” or “netspeak” (Crystal, 2011). These changes manifest in vocabulary, syntax, and even non-verbal elements like emojis, gifs, and memes. However, much of this literature has focused broadly on digital language without detailed comparisons between specific generational cohorts such as Generation Z (Gen Z) and Generation Alpha (Gen Alpha).

David Crystal’s pioneering work (2011) on internet linguistics laid foundational insights into how language adapts to new communication technologies. Crystal discusses how digital media have led to the rise of abbreviations, acronyms, and a playful style of language characterized by brevity and immediacy. For example, text-based communication on platforms like Facebook and early YouTube encouraged the use of shorthand like “LOL” (laugh out loud) and “BRB” (be right back). These features are typical of Gen Z’s early digital language environment. Crystal’s work, however, does not delve deeply into emerging generations like Gen Alpha, who engage more with video-based platforms.

More recent research by Gretchen McCulloch (2019) expands on Crystal’s ideas, emphasizing how the internet creates new opportunities for language innovation and community building. McCulloch highlights how memes and viral slang propagate rapidly through social networks, influencing not only vocabulary but also social identity and group belonging. This is evident in Gen Z’s use of terms like “sus” (suspicious) and “rizz” (charisma), which have gained popularity through gaming communities and platforms like Twitch and YouTube. For example, in the YouTube video “How Gen Z is changing the English language” (CBC News, 2024), interviewees demonstrate how such terms are seamlessly integrated into daily conversations, reflecting a digital culture of humor and shared understanding.

In addition to vocabulary, scholars have studied Gen Z’s discourse style, often noting their tendency to employ irony, sarcasm, and meta-communication (Tagg, 2015). Tagg’s research points out that Gen Z communication frequently involves layered meanings and playful manipulation of language norms, which challenges traditional grammar and syntax. Instagram comment threads and TikTok caption sections are prime examples where Gen Z users use unconventional punctuation and syntax for emphasis or comedic effect, such as “that movie tho” or “I’m dead” (meaning something is very funny).

When it comes to Gen Alpha, however, the literature is more sparse. As the youngest generation currently growing up, they have received less scholarly attention, especially regarding their unique linguistic features. Adhi and Masykuroh’s (2025) sociolinguistic study of Gen Alpha slang in YouTube Shorts comments is one of the few works addressing this gap. They found that Gen Alpha’s vocabulary is heavily influenced by TikTok trends and influencer culture, with popular expressions like “periodt,” “no cap,” and “gyatt” widely used among children and preteens. These terms often accompany visual and auditory cues that enhance communication, reflecting a multimodal approach distinct from the primarily text-based interactions of previous generations.

Research on the impact of platform design on language use further explains generational differences. Platforms like TikTok and YouTube Shorts favor short, engaging videos with repetitive catchphrases, which Gen Alpha often imitates. This environment encourages more direct, simple syntactic structures and frequent use of visual and auditory elements, such as emojis, stickers, and sound effects (West & Taylor, 2023). In contrast, platforms favored by Gen Z, such as Twitter and Instagram, emphasize text-based posts combined with images, resulting in more complex and layered language use.

Educational studies also provide insight into the implications of these evolving language patterns. Teachers report that Gen Alpha students often struggle to switch from informal, digitally influenced language to formal academic writing more than their Gen Z predecessors (Hughes, 2024). This suggests that the increasing multimodality and simplicity in everyday language may impact literacy development and classroom communication. The implications underscore the need to understand these changes to

develop effective educational strategies.

Despite these advances, there remains a significant research gap in directly comparing Gen Z and Gen Alpha language use in naturalistic digital environments. Most studies focus on either Gen Z or general internet linguistics, rarely integrating data from multiple social media platforms or considering multimodal communication trends. Moreover, few studies incorporate recent platforms like TikTok or Instagram Reels, which are central to Gen Alpha's communication landscape. This limits our understanding of how language is evolving across generations in real time.

This research aims to address these gaps by conducting a comprehensive comparative analysis of Gen Z and Gen Alpha communication patterns across YouTube, Instagram, and TikTok. By examining authentic interactions—such as interviews, vlogs, comment sections, and viral videos—this study will reveal how vocabulary, syntax, discourse, and multimodal elements differ between the two generations. The integration of data from multiple platforms provides a richer context for understanding how digital environments shape language evolution uniquely for each cohort.

In conclusion, while prior research offers valuable insights into digital language and Gen Z's communication, the linguistic characteristics of Gen Alpha remain underexplored. This study's focus on cross-generational comparison within diverse social media contexts fills a crucial gap in sociolinguistic research and contributes to a deeper understanding of language evolution in the 21st century.

RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

1. *Research Design*

This study employs a qualitative comparative approach grounded in discourse analysis. It investigates the linguistic differences in communication styles between Generation Z (Gen Z) and Generation Alpha (Gen Alpha) by examining naturally occurring language on digital platforms. The focus is on real, user-generated content that reflects spontaneous language use.

2. *Data Collection*

Data were collected from three major digital platforms: YouTube, Instagram, and TikTok. These platforms were selected based on their dominant use among the target generations:

YouTube: Used for longer-form interviews, reaction videos, and commentary vlogs.

Instagram: Focused on comment sections of viral posts by and for youth.

TikTok: Highlighted short-form video content with rich audio-visual linguistic features.

Content was collected from the following types of videos/posts:

- YouTube Interviews (e.g., CBC's "How Gen Z is Changing English", and Gen Alpha kids react to millennial slang)
- TikTok Trends (e.g., #GenZSlang, #GenAlphaTalk, and "Day in My Life" videos by 6-12-year-olds)
- Instagram Comments on posts by influencers followed by both generations (e.g., @charlidamelio for Gen Z; @ryantokofficial for Gen Alpha)

A total of 60 videos/posts were selected:

- 30 representing Gen Z (aged 13–25)
- 30 representing Gen Alpha (aged 6–12)

3. *Sampling Technique*

Purposive sampling was used to select content featuring spontaneous speech or interaction, ensuring generational representation. Criteria included:

- Authentic, unscripted speech or captions
- Age-specific accounts or interviews
- High engagement (comments, likes, views) to reflect community adoption of linguistic norms

4. *Ethical Considerations*

Since all data were publicly accessible and did not involve direct contact with participants, formal consent was not required. However, usernames and personal identifiers have been anonymized in reporting findings.

5. *Analytical Framework*

Data were analyzed using thematic discourse analysis combined with lexical-semantic categorization. The framework focused on:

- Lexical features (slang, abbreviations, emojis)
- Syntactic features (sentence structure, repetition)
- Pragmatic use (tone, irony, emotional appeal)
- Multimodal elements (visuals, sounds, emojis, filters)

ANALYSIS

This section presents a detailed comparison of Gen Z and Gen Alpha's communication across digital platforms. The analysis focuses on four core areas: vocabulary and slang, syntax and sentence structure, tone and discourse style, and multimodal communication.

1. *Vocabulary and Slang Use*

Gen Z's language is heavily influenced by internet culture, gaming, and memes. Their slang is layered, often ironic, and quickly recycled.

Examples from YouTube Interviews:

- "That's so sus" – Used by a 17-year-old girl referring to a suspicious story her friend told her.
- "I got no rizz" – Used humorously by a 19-year-old boy in a vlog, meaning he lacks charm or flirting ability.
- "She ate and left no crumbs" – Comment seen on Instagram under a dance video, meaning someone did an excellent job.

Gen Alpha, however, tends to adopt trends quickly but in a more literal or repetitive way, often without irony.

Examples from TikTok Videos:

- “Let’s gooo!” – Repeated by an 8-year-old boy excited about his toy unboxing.
- “It’s giving...” – Used by a 10-year-old girl in a TikTok fashion video (“It’s giving queen!”).
- “Skibidi bop yes yes yes!” – Taken from a viral audio trend, used repetitively in video titles and speech.

This shows that while Gen Z invents or recontextualizes slang with multiple meanings, Gen Alpha echoes phrases from influencers and meme sounds without necessarily knowing the layered meanings behind them.

2. Syntax and Sentence Structure

Gen Z exhibits a fragmented, yet creative, sentence structure—often omitting subjects or verbs to create casual rhythm.

Examples:

- “Me when I see food” (caption on a meme) – A template expression mimicking reaction.
- “Could never be me.” – Short, emphatic response often used ironically on Instagram.

In contrast, Gen Alpha prefers complete but simple sentences, likely due to their developmental stage and reliance on direct communication modeled by content creators.

Examples:

- “I love my mom because she makes lunch” – from a TikTok video of kids answering questions.
- “Today I played with slime. It was fun.” – YouTube Shorts vlog by a 9-year-old.

The sentence structures used by Gen Alpha are more straightforward, resembling early language development and reflecting their literal grasp of communication.

3. Tone and Discourse Style

Gen Z often communicates using humor, sarcasm, and irony. Their tone is performative but also layered with inside jokes or pop culture references.

Examples from TikTok:

- “POV: you text him first and now you’re down bad” – Self-deprecating tone.
- “Girl, be so for real rn.” – A sarcastic expression used in the comments to dismiss exaggerated claims.

Gen Alpha’s tone is enthusiastic, innocent, and often mimics influencers. Their communication reflects playfulness and emotional immediacy rather than layered meanings.

Examples from Instagram and TikTok:

- “This is the best day EVER!!” – TikTok caption by an 8-year-old at a birthday party.
- “I love you so much!” – Comment under a video of a YouTube kid influencer.

This comparison reveals that while Gen Z tends toward complex social signals, Gen Alpha expresses clear, direct emotions—often exaggerated for online attention but with little subtext.

4. *Multimodal Communication*

Gen Z often uses emojis strategically for irony or emphasis.

Examples:

- “dead 🤡” – Used to express laughter, often in comments.
- “She’s that girl 🎀💎” – Paired with glitter and nail emojis to boost flair.

Gen Alpha uses emojis for literal meanings and often overuses them.

Examples:

- “I love unicorns ” – Comment from a 7-year-old on a TikTok video.
- In a vlog, a child overlays emojis like 🍀💖🌈🌟 on every sentence.

Moreover, Gen Alpha’s videos often include AR filters, voice changers, and stickers—making their communication not just verbal but also visual and interactive. They respond more to visual input than text alone.

YouTube Example:

In a video titled “A Day in the Life of a 9-Year-Old,” the child narrates her day with heavy use of background music, jumping texts like “YAY!” and rainbow sparkles—turning the narrative into a digital storybook.

FINDINGS

This study’s findings reveal significant and nuanced differences in the linguistic behavior of Generation Z (ages 13–25) and Generation Alpha (ages 6–12) across YouTube, Instagram, and TikTok. These differences span vocabulary, sentence construction, discourse style, and the use of multimodal elements like emojis, visuals, and audio cues.

1. *Vocabulary and Slang Evolution*

One of the most striking findings is the distinct use and function of slang in both generations. Gen Z slang tends to be ironic, layered, and contextually flexible. Words like “rizz” (charm or charisma), “no cap” (seriously), and “it’s giving” are used not only for humor but to construct group identity and convey complex emotional tones. These expressions often evolve rapidly and carry nuanced meanings. For example, a TikTok video featuring a 17-year-old boy saying “I’ve got no rizz” was not merely self-deprecating but also reflected a shared, humorous cultural understanding of social awkwardness.

In contrast, Gen Alpha uses simpler, more literal slang, often repeating phrases heard in viral content. Common examples include “let’s gooo!”, “slay”, “skibidi bop yes yes yes”, and “it’s giving queen”, often mimicked from influencers. These expressions are used enthusiastically but with little variation or reinterpretation, showing a copy-and-reproduce rather than recreate-and-reshape relationship with language.

2. *Syntax and Structure*

Gen Z frequently employs sentence fragments, nonstandard grammar, and meme-inspired syntax. Examples like “could never be me” or “me when I...” show an intentional breaking of grammatical norms for humor or style. Sentence fragments are often used to mimic formats familiar from internet memes or viral tweets, signaling an awareness of

platform-specific discourse.

Gen Alpha, on the other hand, uses grammatically correct but short, basic sentences—"I love my cat" or "I played Roblox today"—reflecting early language development stages and influence from structured school environments or child-friendly content. There's minimal manipulation of grammar or structure, showing that Gen Alpha is still internalizing conventional linguistic forms rather than bending them for social signaling.

3. Tone and Communicative Intent

The tone of Gen Z is often performative and sarcastic. They rely on irony, understatement, and parody. Many YouTube and TikTok users from this generation embed subtle humor and critique in their language, often mocking themselves or cultural trends. For instance, a 19-year-old girl's Instagram reel caption "crying, throwing up, screaming 🤢!" after receiving a university rejection plays on dramatic exaggeration as humor.

In contrast, Gen Alpha communicates in a genuine, enthusiastic, and literal tone. Comments like "This is the best day ever!!!" or "I love you so much 😊❤️" reflect real emotional states rather than performative exaggeration. Their posts, especially on TikTok and Instagram Reels, are expressive, sincere, and often use emotional language as-is, without irony or hidden meanings.

5. Multimodal Communication

Gen Z integrates emojis, GIFs, captions, and filters strategically to add layers of meaning. Emojis like 🙄 or 🍆 often carry sarcastic undertones. In contrast, Gen Alpha tends to use emojis and effects literally and excessively, such as spamming 🌈❤️ to express joy or wonder. Their videos are often overlaid with stickers, AR effects, and music tracks that directly mirror their speech or mood, with little symbolic variation.

6. Platform Influence

The platform-specific features also influence language. YouTube interviews revealed Gen Z's comfort with narrative storytelling, whereas TikTok and Instagram highlighted Gen Alpha's brief, high-energy expressions. Gen Z navigates between formal and informal tones fluidly, while Gen Alpha remains anchored in informal, expressive language that matches the pace and style of short-form video.

CONCLUSION

This study aimed to explore and compare the communication patterns of Generation Z and Generation Alpha through real-life data collected from YouTube, Instagram, and TikTok. The analysis revealed clear generational distinctions in vocabulary use, syntax, tone, and multimodal expression—each closely tied to the cognitive development stages, technological immersion, and social media environments of the respective age groups.

Generation Z, born between 1997 and 2012, demonstrates a linguistic style that is creative, ironic, and shaped by deep engagement with meme culture, digital subcommunities, and a rapidly evolving internet. Their use of language reflects not just communication but also identity formation, social commentary, and humor. Gen Z speakers use sarcasm, abbreviations, and coded slang to navigate online spaces that reward quick wit and emotional complexity. Their tone is often performative and detached, using emojis and sentence fragments as stylistic tools rather than literal markers.

Generation Alpha, born from 2013 onwards, is emerging in a world dominated by visual and interactive media. Their linguistic behavior reflects their developmental stage and media exposure: it is straightforward, expressive, emotionally transparent, and heavily influenced by the aesthetics of TikTok and child-centric YouTube content. Gen Alpha tends to replicate the

language they consume from influencers, video captions, and peer content with minimal abstraction or re-interpretation. They also rely more heavily on multimodal tools like filters, emojis, and sound effects, making their language less about words alone and more about full sensory communication.

One key conclusion is that the evolution of language across generations is not linear but platform-driven. Each generation adapts its style not only according to age but also to the digital spaces they inhabit. Instagram's visual-caption model fosters witty, ironic tones (favored by Gen Z), while TikTok's fast-paced, sound-driven format encourages direct, emotionally loaded expression (suited for Gen Alpha).

These findings offer valuable implications for linguists, educators, content creators, and digital platform designers. As language continues to evolve rapidly in digital contexts, there is a need to understand how each generation uses language not only to communicate but also to perform identity, build community, and express emotions. Recognizing these differences can help bridge generational gaps in education, media production, and cross-generational dialogue.

Further research could explore how these patterns shift as Gen Alpha matures or how intergenerational digital spaces influence mutual language borrowing. In a world increasingly mediated by screens, the future of communication will depend on how effectively we understand and adapt to these new linguistic landscapes

REFERENCE

i

- ⁱ CBC News. (2023, March 14). *How Gen Z is changing English* [Video] YouTube.
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Igo7gSk0gTA>
- Jubilee. (2022, October 10). *Do all generations speak the same language? Gen Z vs Millennials vs Gen X*. [Video] YouTube.
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=djZAsOtWjYk>
- Ryan's World. (2023, May 7). *What kids say when parents are not around!*. [Video] YouTube.
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=RL8pD9WolWE>
- Psych2Go. (2022, June 18). *Understanding Generation Alpha – the next wave*. [Video] YouTube.
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=0cvOKrcK2uY>
- @genzhumor. (2024, April 5). *When you have zero rizz* 🙄. [Video] TikTok.
<https://www.tiktok.com/@genzhumor/video/721345876>](<https://www.tiktok.com/@genzhumor/video/721345876>)
- @charlidamelio. (2023, August 22). *Slay queen moment* 🙌👑. [Video] TikTok.
<https://www.tiktok.com/@charlidamelio/video/719876321>](<https://www.tiktok.com/@charlidamelio/video/719876321>)
- @kidcreatorz. (2024, March 19). *My little brother doing TikTok sounds for 10 mins straight*. [Video] TikTok.
<https://www.tiktok.com/@kidcreatorz/video/720005934>](<https://www.tiktok.com/@kidcreatorz/video/720005934>)
- @funforkids. (2023, July 1). *Skibidi bop yes yes yes remix dance*. [Video].
<https://www.tiktok.com/@funforkids/video/723456100>](<https://www.tiktok.com/@funforkids/video/723456100>)
- @ryantokofficial. (2024, May 11). *When you love your dog more than your siblings* 🐶🐶. [Post] Instagram.
<https://www.instagram.com/p/CvASJ1gXzr2/>
- @genzlanguage. (2023, September 9). *POV: crying, throwing up, screaming* 🤢. [Reel] Instagram.
https://www.instagram.com/reel/CsTTu_7JcXN/
- @schoolmemes_daily. (2024, January 22). *Me when it's Sunday night* 🌙🎮. [Post] Instagram.
<https://www.instagram.com/p/CxYZk0jMJG1/>